

The Elephant Man

Fredrick Treves - Amna

John Merrick - Rhea

Mrs. Kendal - Tia

Ross - Tia

Carr Gomm - Amna

Narrator - Natalie

Start the play with an introduction of the characters and who is who. Give a short background of the characters too.

Exposition

(Natalie steps forward, spotlight)

Narrator (Natalie): Welcome to Victorian London, a city steeped in wealth and sophistication. But beneath the polished etiquette and refined curiosity lies a world of exploitation and quiet cruelty. And in the heart of this divided city, we find one such man: John Merrick.

(Tia walks towards the door and lets Rhea in)

Ross (Tia): Come on and look here, look at this remarkable creature alive.

(Shows Rhea off) (Rhea waves to the class)

Look at this monstrous, ugly man. His name is the Elephant Man.

Ross (Tia): Also, he isn't for the faint of heart. The Elephant Man's body is full of deformities; one of his arms is like a tree trunk, and his skin is like leather.

Narrator (Natalie): But under all of this spectacle is John Merrick, a man whose gentle heart and brilliant mind are as yet unknown to the ridiculing and fearful public.

(Rhea steps up to the center.)

Merrick (Rhea): I'm not an animal. I'm a human being...just like all of you around me

Inciting Incident

Narrator (Natalie): Amid the crowds, there is one man who does not gawk but merely observes: Dr. Frederick Treves, a lecturer of anatomy and a surgeon at the London Hospital. He sees Merrick's potential not as a freak but as a subject of scientific curiosity and medical potential.

(Amna steps up with a thoughtful expression and notebook in her hand)

(Touches Rhea on the shoulder)

Treves (Amna): May I examine you? Ross, let's have an exchange. I want Merrick.

(Tia shrugs)

Ross (Tia):

Don't worry, because everything is on sale.

(Tia leans in)

But you should be careful because once you show him to the world, the world might not want him back, and it'll be harder to close the box.

Narrator (Natalie): Treves pays Ross, Merrick's manager, and brings Merrick to the hospital. Where Merrick begins to be treated as a man for the first time, rather than just an exhibit.

(Amna pays Tia fake money, and they both shake hands. Amna escorts Rhea to her room)

(Rhea looks around with a smile forming)

Merrick (Rhea): Do I finally get a peaceful room to call my own?

Rising Action

Narrator (Natalie): Merrick flourishes at London Hospital, reading Shakespeare and the Bible and constructing intricate models. Yet he still dreams of living as an ordinary man.

(Amna hands Rhea a book and smiles)

Treves (Amna): You've shown more courage than most I've met. But is that enough for the world?

Merrick (Rhea): I want to live like the others do. I want to be able to speak without fear and be seen as a simple human being when I go out into society.

Narrator (Natalie): Enter Mrs. Kendal, a celebrated actress, who pays frequent visits to Merrick not out of pity, but respect for his mind and heart.

(Tia enters)

Mrs. Kendal (Tia): Mr. Merrick, your words are so sweet. *(Tia shakes Rhea and pets her head)* They are way more poetic than many that I've previously heard on stage.

(Rhea smiles and clasps Tia's hand)

Merrick (Rhea): You speak to me with respect, as if I were like the rest.

Narrator (Natalie): Yet for all of Merrick's progress, society's gaze remains unchanged, still steeped in pity and voyeurism. He has simply become a different kind of exhibit in his new life of greater comfort.

(Rhea steps closer to the audience)

Merrick (Rhea): I find peace in this church, a place free from harsh judgment and stares.

Climax

Narrator (Natalie): But the shadows of Merrick's past won't be so easily left behind, as Ross returns, once again eager to exploit Merrick.

Ross (Tia): You're famous now! Good job, Johnny!

(Puts a high-five up for Rhea)

Imagine all the shows we can do in so many places, like in London, Paris. Maybe even in America????

(Rhea rejects the high-five and pushes Tia's hand down)

Merrick (Rhea): No! I am not an object that you own!

(Amna grabs Rhea and pulls her away from Tia)

Treves (Amna): Leave him. He is not your spectacle anymore.

(Rhea starts tearing up)

Merrick (Rhea): Their smiles feel so fake, like a facade. No matter what I say or do, I remain mysterious to them.

Narrator (Natalie): His isolation deepens, not from lack of company, but from the absence of true connection.

(Tia walks in, and takes Rhea's hand)

Mrs. Kendal (Tia): Merrick, my sweets, you've taught me how blind I was to what it means to be human. Thank you. Don't you worry, you have made me smile.

Falling Action

Narrator (Natalie): Merrick's body weakens. Though he has gained dignity, friends, and admiration, his physical pain becomes unbearable.

Treves (Amna): You must never lie flat, John. You know what will happen...

(Rhea sits on a desk)

Merrick (Rhea): My dying wish is to be normal for once... to sleep like the others do.

Narrator (Natalie): Dr. Treves has warned Merrick that lying flat would be fatal. Due to his condition, Merrick is unable to sleep lying flat. If he does, his neck could collapse. Yet, Merrick's longing for normalcy outweighs his regard for his own safety.

(Tia starts to wipe her tears)

Mrs. Kendal (Tia): Of course, you deserve to feel at peace. You've been through so many of my sweets.

Narrator (Natalie): This wish represents a last attempt to reclaim some semblance of normalcy from a life shaped by deformity and ostracization.

(Rhea lies down on the desk, Tia wipes away a tear)

Resolution

Narrator (Natalie): Merrick dies in the night, having chosen dignity over continued survival in a life that never truly felt like his own.

(Amna kneels near Rhea and is very shaken)

Treves (Amna): You were the bravest man I've ever known. It was a great honor to spend time with you.

(Amna folds her hands)

Gomm (Amna): May his soul rest knowing he finally lived...as a man.

(Tia wipes her tears)

Mrs. Kendal (Tia): His heart is beautiful, but I think it's too weak and delicate for this world

Narrator (Natalie): Merrick's life comes to an end, but his story endures as both a tragedy and a mirror of society's cruelty, its capacity for compassion, and the complexities of identity and human dignity.

(Amna faces the audience)

Treves (Amna): We could not cure him...but perhaps we came to understand him.

Closing

Narrator (Natalie): And so, let us not forget: true beauty lies not in appearance, but in empathy. Merrick's life, marked by both cruelty and kindness, forces us to confront the ways we respond to those who seem different. His story reflects both the best and worst of human nature, our capacity to isolate as well as to embrace, to judge, and also to understand. In a world still shaped by superficial judgments, let his life be a quiet rebellion against appearances and a call to deeper compassion. Let Merrick's story continue to challenge how we define humanity, dignity, and difference, and remind us that to truly see someone is the beginning of honoring their life.

